Li Zhang

+1 412-328-6886 | liz239@pitt.edu | Homepage | LinkedIn | Google Scholar

Education

University of Pittsburgh — Pittsburgh, PA, U.S.A.
Doctor of Philosophy in Intelligent Systems (Artificial Intelligence) — *Aug. 2024 - Apr. 2028*
- Research: NLP for legal reasoning, trustworthy LLMs, agentic AI, and system evaluation
- Advisor: Prof. Kevin Ashley
- Courses: Large Language Models (Carnegie Mellon University), Natural Language Processing

Tsinghua University — Beijing, China
Master of Computational Law — *Sep. 2019 - Jun. 2022*
- Research: Computational Law

Australian National University — Canberra, Australia
Study Abroad in College of Engineering and Computer Science — *Jul. 2017 - Dec. 2017*
- GPA: 6.5/7.0

China University of Mining and Technology — Jiangsu, China
Bachelor of Electrical Engineering — *Sep. 2015 - Jun. 2019*
- GPA: 90.91/100, Ranking: 2/278

Technical Experience

Thomson Reuters Labs — Eagan, MN, U.S.A.
Applied Research Intern — *May 2026 - Aug. 2026*
- Conducted applied research on long-term memory for AI agents, supporting deep research over long legal documents and long-form content generation with direct commercial applications in litigation and transactional workflows.
- Built and evaluated agent pipelines across dataset optimization, model adaptation, and automated assessment; partnered with science, product, and engineering teams to deliver tailored solutions for grounded workflows.

Selected Publications

1. **DLawBench: Evaluating LLMs Through Multi-Turn Legal Consultation** [Link]
Li Zhang, Yuzhen Shi, Yiran Hu, Jingwen Zhang, Wenbo Lv, Yubo Ma, Wei Wang, Rongyao Shi, Yuanyang Qiu, Xinran Xu, Yuemeng Qi, Linlin Miao, Jaromir Savelka, Yun Liu, Kevin Ashley, Bing Zhao, Hu Wei, Lin Qu
EMNLP 2026 Main Conference

2. **PLawBench: A Rubric-Based Benchmark for Evaluating LLMs in Real-World Legal Practice** [Link]
Yuzhen Shi, Huanghai Liu, Yiran Hu, Song gaojie, Xu Xinran, Yubo Ma, Tianyi Tang, **Li Zhang**, Qingjing Chen, Feng Di, Wenbo Lv, Weiheng Wu, Kexin Yang, Sen Yang, Wei Wang, Rongyao Shi, Qiuyuan Yang, Yuemeng Qi, Jingwen Zhang, Xiaoyu Sui, Yifan Chen, Yi Zhang, An Yang, Bowen Yu, Dayiheng Liu, Junyang Lin, Weixin Shen, Bing Zhao, Charles Clarke, Hu Wei
ACL 2026 Main Conference

3. **Where Do Legal Factors Live in LLMs?** [Link]
Li Zhang, Kevin Ashley
JURIX 2026

4. **DenseMixer: Improving MoE Post-Training with Precise Router Gradient** [Link]
Feng Yao, Junxia Cui, Ruohan Zhang, Liyuan Liu, Shibo Hao, **Li Zhang**, Chengyu Dong, Shuohang Wang, Yelong Shen, Jianfeng Gao, Jingbo Shang
EMNLP 2026 Main Conference

5. **Thinking Longer, Not Always Smarter: Evaluating LLM Capabilities in Hierarchical Legal Reasoning** [Link]
Li Zhang, Matthias Grabmair, Morgan Gray, Kevin Ashley
CS&Law 2026

6. **Do LLMs Truly Understand When a Precedent Is Overruled?** [Link]
Li Zhang, Jaromir Savelka, Kevin Ashley
JURIX 2025, ***Best Student Paper***

7. **Retrieval-Based Multi-Label Legal Annotation: Extensible, Data-Efficient and Hallucination-Free** [Link]
Li Zhang, Jaromir Savelka, Kevin Ashley
ICAIL 2026

8. **Mitigating Manipulation and Enhancing Persuasion: A Reflective Multi-Agent Approach for Legal Argument Generation** [Link]
Li Zhang, Kevin Ashley
ICAIL 2025 Workshop

9. **Generating Case-Based Legal Arguments with LLMs** [Link]
Morgan Gray, **Li Zhang**, Kevin Ashley
CS&Law 2025

Research Projects

Benchmarking LLM Long-Context Understanding and Temporal Logic Pittsburgh, PA, U.S.A.
***Li Zhang**, Jaromir Savelka, Kevin Ashley* *Sep. 2024 – Present*

- Built a legal-corpus benchmark for long-context and temporal reasoning over overruling relationships, with metrics for temporal bias, robustness, hallucination, and grounding in controlling precedent.

Reflective Multi-Agent Frameworks for Ethical Legal Persuasion Pittsburgh, PA, U.S.A.
***Li Zhang**, Kevin Ashley* *Aug. 2024 – Present*

- Developed a reflective multi-agent framework whose critic agents verify legal arguments against factual records, with inspectable guardrails against manipulation and fabricated evidence.

Evaluating and Enhancing Hierarchical Legal Reasoning Pittsburgh, PA, U.S.A.
***Li Zhang**, Matthias Grabmair, Morgan Gray, Kevin Ashley* *Nov. 2024 – Present*

- Evaluated reasoning collapse in multi-stage legal tasks and developed hierarchical inference strategies for robust case distinctions and nuanced deductions in complex case law.

Financial & Legal Experience

The Export-Import Bank of China, Jiangsu Branch Nanjing, China
Legal Counselor *Jun. 2022 - Jun. 2024*

- Led negotiation and execution of cross-border structured financing and trade-finance transactions at a state policy bank, advising on credit risk, counterparty exposure, and regulatory compliance.
- Drafted and reviewed credit facility and security documentation; advised deal teams on transaction structuring, operational risk, and dispute resolution, building first-hand knowledge of financial markets and banking products.

Talks

1. Do LLMs Truly Understand When a Precedent Is Overruled, 2025 Pittsburgh Legal AI Summit, Carnegie Mellon University
2. Mitigating Manipulation and Enhancing Persuasion: A Reflective Multi-Agent Approach for Legal Argument Generation, ResearchTrend.AI
3. Enhancing Legal Argument Generation: From Basic Schemes to Trustworthy Multi-Agent Systems, ISP Forum, University of Pittsburgh

Skills & Qualifications

- **Research:** Statistical learning, LLM evaluation and benchmarking, multi-agent systems, interpretability, and document intelligence
- **Programming:** Python (PyTorch, Scikit-learn, Pandas and NumPy), R, C/C++, MATLAB, SQL, JavaScript
- **Cloud Technologies:** SageMaker, DynamoDB and API Gateway
- **Finance & Law:** PRC Legal Professional Qualification; two years of cross-border financing and credit transaction experience in commercial banking
- **Others:** LaTeX, Markdown, Linux, Shell and Anaconda